

Project Proposal & Group Charter

by Emily, Feruza & Dunya

Research Question

What workforce patterns can be identified in the eighteenth-century VOC dataset, and how might these patterns relate to the company's decline?

Thesis Statement

We argue that the VOC's decline was foreshadowed in its workforce patterns: a growing reliance on foreign recruits, persistently high levels of mortality and desertion, and limited opportunities for career advancement created instability within the organization. By analyzing these patterns in the dataset, our project highlights how workforce dynamics may have contributed to the eventual collapse of the company.

Current Relevance

When reviewing literature on the topic of the Dutch East India Compagnie it became apparent that there is a broad range of papers on this topic. However, while searching for articles on workforce patterns in relation to the VOC declination we found that this topic has received minimal attention. We found that the main themes in research on the VOC often focuses on the management aspects of the VOC empire (Gaastra, 2007), (Parthesius, 2010) or the shadow side of the VOC: slave trading (Chakraborty, 2019), (Mbeki & Van Rossum, 2016). Therefore we attempt to obtain more insights on the working conditions of the VOC. For external context outside the dataset we have a look at how the VOC adapted its policies beneficial to solve internal problems (Wezel & Ruef, 2017). Also, we found that Rei (2012) provides in depth information based on career records of 115 VOC workers gathered by Frank Lequin (1982). Rei lays out specifics like ranks, wages, hierarchy and return rates of VOC personnel. We note however that the data stems from very early research that we are unable to locate digitally which leads us to treat this information with precaution. Since our research focuses on VOC workforce patterns, we also take a look at the deployment of Chinese sailors in the VOC as described in Promises and Predicaments (2015), a chapter by Leonard Blussé. Furthermore, we argue that VOC's patterns may not have been unique, since similar workforce vulnerabilities have also been observed in other large organizations, such as the British East India Company (Stern, 2011). Additional literature will inevitably adjoin as our research process develops.

Dataset Description and Problematization

The original ‘VOC-opvarenden’ dataset contains 774,200 muster records from 1633 to 1794. These records include variables such as crew members’ names, places of origin, ranks. Through careful disambiguation, the dataset has been refined to identify 460,452 individuals, with standardized place names, categorized ranks, and integrated wage information.

In terms of representativeness, the dataset is unique for its exceptional size. It spans over 160 years, offering both temporal depth and a broad European coverage. The standardized place names and rank categories make it possible to analyze patterns in workforce origins and social composition at a scale previously unattainable.

However, it only covers VOC personnel who signed on in the Netherlands, thereby excluding those recruited in Asia or other regions of the VOC empire. The clustering process may include inaccuracies, and approximately 18% of records lack precise place information. (Petram et al., 2024)

Last, it also embodies biases. Recruitment records reflect only those who formally signed contracts, leaving out deserters, unregistered workers, or auxiliary personnel. The emphasis on European enlistment creates a Eurocentric view of the VOC’s labor force, obscuring other workers who played crucial roles in the company’s operations but were less systematically documented.

Action Plan

To answer our research question, we will analyze muster records from 1700 to 1780, when the dataset offers near-complete coverage of voyages (Petram et al., 2024). Earlier data are fragmentary, and the final decades are less consistent due to chartered ships and foreign regiments. This focus provides a reliable basis for tracing workforce patterns.

We will preprocess the dataset by linking origin entries to standardized place names in `voc_places_standardized.csv` and grouping them into the nine historical-geographical regions (A-I) defined by the curators. We acknowledge that this standardization may contain inaccuracies, but we consider it the best option because it makes the data workable, comparable with existing research, and sufficient for studying broad trends.

Ranks will be consolidated into six categories (Sea, Ship, Trade, Medical, Military, Other) and arranged in an ordered ladder to reflect career progression. Contract outcomes will be simplified into four groups: Repatriated, Death (including deceased, shipwrecked, executed), Attrition (deserted or dismissed), and Ambiguous (missing or last record).

Our main analysis will use descriptive statistics and visualizations to identify patterns in origins, ranks, and outcomes, as well as their changes over time. Regression models (ordered logistic and multinomial) will be applied to test whether these patterns are systematic. If time allows, we will also run survival analysis and create advanced visualizations such as Sankey diagrams and Kaplan-Meier curves.

Team Chart

Our goal is to deliver a high-quality proposal, aiming for a grade in the 8-10 range. We set internal deadlines to finish at least 24 hours before submission. Emily wants to improve cross-disciplinary writing, Feruza focuses on working with the dataset and visualizations, and Dunya develops literature and referencing skills.

Roles are divided so that Feruza prepares and analyzes the data, Emily leads on writing and editing, and Dunya handles literature review and APA referencing. This ensures each member has both a main task and a support role.

Pressures include Dunya's exam, Emily's weekly assignments, and Feruza's care duties on Wednesdays. We communicate mainly through WhatsApp with a response time of about two hours and plan two meetings per assignment, with extra check-ins when needed.

Referencelist

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